I Don't Want to be Crazy

By Samantha Schutz

(Pg 1-2) I can't believe
no one else can hear
I am screaming
inside my head.

Things are moving so fast.
I am going to die.
I am going to die.
I am going to die.
My hands are shaking.
I try to squeeze them, try to make it stop,
but now my fists are shaking,
and this shaking is working its way through me.
It must look like I am having a fit.
I want to let the scream out,
but I think if I start,
I'll never stop.

It's not supposed to be like this.
I am too young to die.
I don't know how to make this end,
and if it doesn't, I'll have to go to a hospital,
be medicated, force-fed soft foods.
I am not that person.

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I am not.
I am not.

INTRODUCTION

According to the National Institute of Mental Health, Anxiety disorders are the most common mental illness in the US, affecting 40 million adults every year. Sure, everyone experiences feelings of anxiety and even panic sometimes. It's a natural response to stressful or dangerous situations.

BUT for someone with a panic disorder, overwhelming emotions appear regularly and for no apparent reason. Instead of seeking help, most struggle to hide the attacks, fearing that they will a best be judged by those around them, and a worst be deemed "crazy" by society.

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(Pg 7-8) Applying to college was a disaster.
My parents had their choice for me,
and I had mine.
But since they were paying the bills ,
there was no room for compromise.

We fought about my application essay for weeks>
It has to be perfect --
revised and reread dozens of times,
market up in red pen
until it was bloody.

In the end my personal statement
was more my mother's than my own
and fiction became fact
because it sounded better.

It's been like this
for as long as I can remember --
writing and rewriting homework,
book reports, and papers
until they were not mine --
until they were perfect.

(Pg 12) I can't wait
to get out of this room
out of this house
with all its rules,
out of this neighborhood
where everyone knows each other.

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(Pg 22-23) Living with Sarah the first few weeks
is like an extended sleepover party.
Our dorm room isn't big,
but I can be anything I want here.
No one has to know
that I wasn't popular in high school,
that I've never stayed out all night.

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I'm taking art classes, writing classes, dance classes --
all the things there was no room for before.

I reread Anais Nin's journals

> **(Pg i)** It takes courage to push yourself to places that you have never been before . . . to test your limits . . . to break through barriers. And the day came when the risk it took to remain tight inside the bud was more painful than the risk it took to blossom – Anais Nin

And write in my own.

But . . .
(Pg 36-39) I can't sit still in class.
I can't hear what the teacher is saying.
All I can hear is my voice in my head
telling me that things are not right --
that I am not right.
It feels like something is trying to push its way out of me,
out of my chest.

I have to get out of here. *(coughing)*
I fake a coughing fit and leave
I'm trapped – stuck inside of this shaking, sweating body.
The only place that seems save
is the bathroom.
Sitting in the stall, with my chest on my thighs,
I try to breathe,

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But the more I think about my breathing,
the more I feel like I can't breathe.
It feels like my insides are melting.
This must be what it feels like the moment before you die.

I have been telling myself
that these feeling are new,
but they aren't.

I felt it the firs time junior year.
It felt like my chest caved in
and I couldn't tell the difference
between the bass in the music
and a car alarm going off outside.
I couldn't get my mind to stop racing.

It happened again, before college.
I was in Staples with my dad,
shopping for school supplies.
All of a sudden the ground felt soft
and the sounds around me
were too fast and too slow
at the same time.

I though I would lose control,
do something crazy – start screaming
right there in the pen aisle.
My dad would know.

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Everyone would know.

Now this feeling follows me
everywhere I go.
It clings to me,
Makes my skin crawl.
It sits with me in class,
whispers in my ear,
tells me that I shouldn't be here.
(Pg 45) I have resigned myself
to the fact that I have gone insane.
I am too tired
to keep fighting
the empty feeling in my stomach
and the buzzing in my head.

This was not supposed to be how things turned out.
There were steps taken, expectations --
a specialized kindergarten and elementary school,
a prestigious private high school
summer study program disguised as camp.

This is not how things are supposed to be.
(Pg 47) I am in Health Services again,
waiting for the nurse to look me over,
to take my temperature,
listen to my heart and lungs<

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To tell me that I am okay,
when I see a poster on the wall
that says, “Having Panic Attacks?

For the first time in weeks
things make sense
(Pg 50-51) Panic attacks are
feelings of dying,
going crazy,
losing control of emotions and behavior.
I have the urge to
escape of flee.

Sometimes I have five a day.
This is my life.

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(Pg 130-131) Backed up against the brick wall,
I cannot trust this body.
I run inside, slam the door shut, and get into bed.

The bathroom light is on
And the door is open.
I hear it . . .
You will get up and put your head in the toilet.
What will my parents think in the morning
when I’m found dead,

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head in the bowl?
In my head I hear, *This is not a choice.*
I tell myself over and over,
I am stronger than you, stronger than you,
stronger than you.

(Pg 40) Please God make this feeling stop.
I can’t take it.
Breathe. Breathe. Breathe.
Make it stop. Please. *(Beat)*

(Pg 131) I am scared of myself,
I tell my therapist.
I don’t think
I want to kill myself, I say.
She tells me this is common
for people who have anxiety disorder.

(Pg 68) Little yellow pills
for the one who cannot control her adrenaline, her fear
Little yellow pills
for a child who cannot deal with being an adult.
Little yellow pills
to make me forget.
(Pg 53) Klonopin 0.6 mg
I take one in the morning
and one at night.
It makes me sleep,

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makes the panic a voice in the distance --
loud enough to hear,
but quiet enough to ignore.

(Pg 218) My therapist wants to know
how my panic attacks serve me.
I don't understand.
He wants to know what I gain from them.
Gain?
He thinks they serve a purpose.
I still don't understand.
Is he saying that I do this to myself
To avoid situations I don't want to be in?
To myself?
I am crying as I talk
and there must be little threads of spit
connecting my upper and lower jaw.
To myself?
I have never heard anything so awful in my life.

(Pg 243) Why would I do this to myself?
Why would I inflict this much pain,
turn my life upside down,
twist my stomach in knots,
run from friends, family?
(panic attack begins; breathing to try to control it)
(Pg 246) Long slow breaths. Deep breaths.

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(Pg 241) No one said I was going to be this sad.
No one said I would still be crying.

I am so lonely,
Every day is the same --
trying to move slower than the rest,
To not be so angry,
so serious in the morning,
to not make myself crazy.

(Pg 258) I am scared to sleep
I am scared to eat.
I am scared to move.
And all this turns my stomach
and reminds me how alone I am
and how pitiful it is
that I need someone to love me,
to wrap me up and make me feel safe<
and how pathetic it is
that I can't find someone, anyone
to do that for me. *(Long beat)*

(Pg 267-228) I wonder what my life would be like
if I'd never had anxiety disorder.
At first I think,
I'd be Miss America.
I'd be the happiest person

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with the brightest smile on the face of the earth>
But the more I think about it,
The more scary life with out panic seems.
My life has been governed by anxiety.
It fills up my time.
I only know how to live like this --
with this feeling in my stomach.

When I have a panic attack
the voice in my head says
anything can happen.
I will go insane,
I will die,
I will start screaming.
(Panic attack begins and she speaks as she tries to control it with breathing)
I try to tell myself that that voice isn't real,
but it's hard.
The voice is very convincing . . .

(Pg 2) It's not supposed to be like this.
I am too young to die.
I don't know how to make this end,
and if it doesn't, I'll have to go to a hospital,
be medicated, force-fed soft foods.
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